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EVENING WALKERS A wild elephant goes shopping for trouble in a Guwahati market; a lioness in Amreli, Gujarat

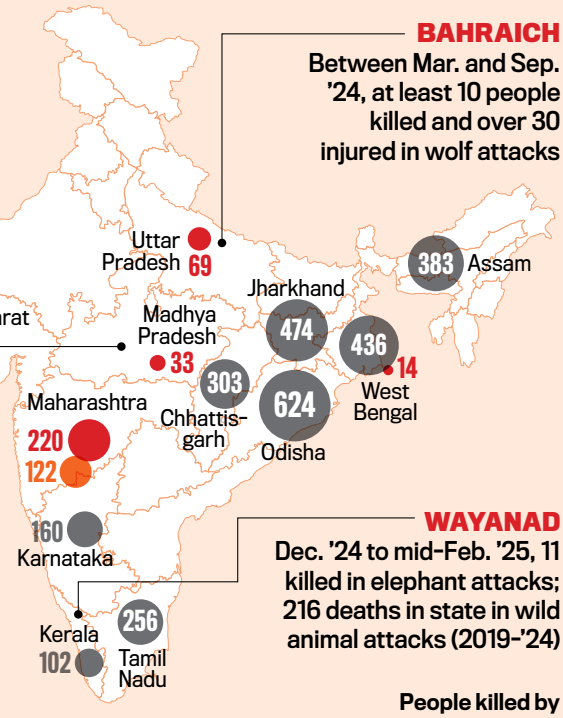
DEADLY ENCOUNTERS

BHOPAL
'Urban tigers of Bhopal' have made open forests of Kaliasot dam their home

AMRELI
At least one lion pride have made Pipavav Port their home. Over three dozen people killed in Gujarat in lion/leopard attacks (2021-'24)

BAHRAICH
Between Mar. and Sep. '24, at least 10 people killed and over 30 injured in wolf attacks

WAYANAD
Dec. '24 to mid-Feb. '25, 11 killed in elephant attacks; 216 deaths in state in wild animal attacks (2019-'24)



People killed by
Elephant Tiger Leopard
between 2019-'24

Source: MoEFCC data

animal familiarity with human habitats, including urban and peri-urban zones. Recently, the attention of biologists has been drawn to videos of wild elephants waiting calmly for vehicles to pass before crossing a highway near the Raimona National Park in Assam. An odd turn, for all behavioural studies have hitherto marked elephants as immensely human-shy creatures, not exactly obedient citizens with civic sense. And at least one pride of Asiatic lions is known to jay-walk around highways, jetties and railway yards around Gujarat's Pipavav Port, leisurely inspecting the gigantic containers—on odd occasions, a lioness even rests with her cubs in an open container.

For centuries, human beings have invaded the habitats of the wild, felling forests for timber, clearing thick canopies for farmlands and urban sprawls; mined the earth for minerals and oil; broken mountains for quarries and highways; invaded the seas with trawlers, toxic discharges and what have you. The 2024 report of Living Planet, WWF, reveals an average 73 per cent decline, between 1970 and 2020, in the population sizes of over 5,000 vertebrate species. Several have perished. But many more have survived—and adapted. It's a large-scale behavioural shift where, as scientists are observing, they are increasingly shedding their shy, reclusive nature, which entails aggression upon encounter. Instead, they are showing up at our doorstep—looking for food, shelter and safe breeding spots. With humankind pretty much colonising all of the planet, scientists are even speaking of a new phase of animal evolution. The old abhorrence of our two-legged presence may be gradually, grudgingly perhaps, yielding to coexistence. Aritra Kshettry, National Lead for Elephant Conservation, WWF-India, calls it "co-adaptation between humans and non-humans in shared spaces". While reptiles, birds, primates and small mammals were always known to thrive in urban spaces, "even large mammals like leopards, elephants and tigers have adapted to living in peri-urban spaces", he says.

Is it good news? No. The answer is deeply layered and complicated. A quick primer. Scientists classify wild species into two: 'K-selected' and 'R-selected'. The first are large, produce fewer offspring, and are prone to extinction if their ecosystems change. Exhibit A: elephants, whales. 'R-selected' species birth more progeny, and more often. As long as they get food and undisturbed space to rest and reproduce, they will adapt and survive. The leopard, a skulking presence just off our city limits, is such a versatile big cat. Its broad diet spectrum has enabled this shy, elusive feline to survive around densely population zones such as Mumbai, Delhi-NCR, Bengaluru and Shimla. What the recent incidents and studies demonstrate is that the R-selected fauna are really reclaiming territory that's now human habitation—paradoxically, owing to wildlife conservation efforts.

SCIENTISTS SEE **A LARGE-SCALE BEHAVIOURAL SHIFT WHERE EVEN BIG FAUNA ARE SHEDDING THEIR SHY, RECLUSIVE NATURE** AND EVOLVING MODES OF CO-EXISTENCE

The K-selected species face more un-